

On Reactions to Objectivity in Print Capitalism, Fake News, and Social Media

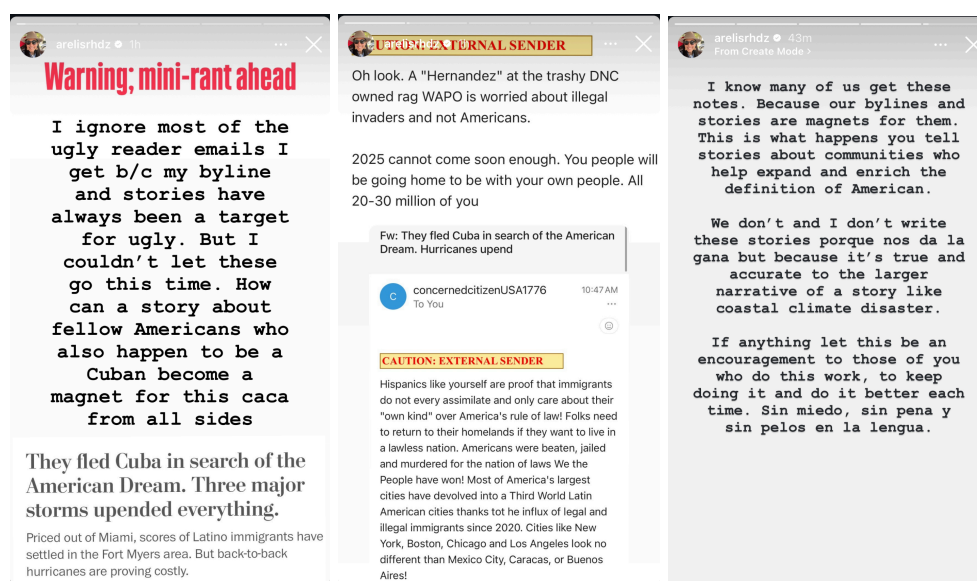
On the last night of a summer journalism program last year, everyone huddled into a small lounge at American University. The thirty of us students sat on the ground while our six mentors, all professional journalists, sat on the TV stand. Instead of letting us sleep at 10 p.m. that day, the mentors told us to meet them there. From fashionably dressed reporters to slothish high school students again, we filtered into the small room like ducklings. Over empty juice boxes and the crinkle of chip bags, our mentors swore us to secrecy—"What is said in this room stays in this room"—before hitting us with stories of experiences we could not dare simulate a press conference for. In a stark turn of topics, we were pulled out of what we previously knew as the secret lives of multitalented journalists and into the vulnerabilities that come with being one.

One was a teen mother, who made terrible decisions in the past but decided to do her best and is now the director of the capital's top broadcasting station. One is the best anchor in the Midwest but at the cost of barely being able to rest or return home to family. One has been brushing shoulders with celebrities for three decades, and was an alcoholic and severe party-goer for years before owning up to the shame to himself—he's now eight years sober and the best TV/comedy critic I know. One grew up in a town where cows outnumber people, was homeless for years in New York City, and changed suits in the bathrooms of McDonalds to prepare for job interviews. He now works for Bloomberg overseas, and, I bet, secretly takes pride in his name being on the United Arab Emirates' blacklist. One is a very strong writer and the most calm person I know who follows migrant families on the Texan border and tells the painful stories of migrant families who had their children taken away from them in school shootings. She told us she broke down several times when writing the stories, to the point where she considered quitting during the pandemic. Our sixth mentor looked way younger than he was; he was expecting his first baby soon. For someone we knew as an always goofy, happy guy, we were reminded that behind the duty of being great journalists was also our natural identities as mothers, fathers, brothers, sisters, and humans who are constantly weighing right from wrong.

There was nothing we could do but sniffle in tears. Huddled in this tiny lounge, scared of nothing but an unknown tension, we comforted each other in silence and mixed looks. The fear didn't last long. It took bravery and shaky voices for us younger journalists to speak out about our own worries. Deep inside, we already knew pursuing journalism as a career would be unpredictable. But hours later, after our mentors sent us to our rooms downstairs, most of us lingered secretly in the hallway whispering fears of a rapidly changing future with or without our love for journalism.

The entire story likely makes us sound babyish, and understandably so: by day, we were exquisite, expressionless, pseudo-professionals but by night, we were boys and girls with tear-stained cheeks but all eyes and ears to hearing our peers out, patting them on the back, rubbing each other's hands in comfort. However, anyone who is in the journalism industry may sympathize with this feeling very well or even wish to find a group like this to support and be supported. Likewise, they would also recognize that hearing the vulnerable stories of journalists is something seldom visible in the public sphere, albeit it is undoubtedly important.

I've been a journalist for seven years now, but I'm still not nearly as skilled as my mentors. However, I have learned a bit how to dance the line between journalistic duty and personal identity. Journalists are people too, and we write our stories and choose exact words for our headlines and text because that's what people read first and decide if they want to read further. That's why when I see ugly emails from readers, I've learned to take it with a grain of salt; one more ugly email means one more conversation sparked by my work. But when I see ugly emails like in the middle photo below:



(Teresa Fang)

of course, I'm compelled to react. This is a post by one of my journalism mentors, Washington Post journalist Arelis Hernández, in response to racism and hate, in which her stories have made her a target for hateful emails and comments. Before we dismiss this as a regular ugly email, this was a human-interest story about resilience and the American Dream which these emails politicized as a target for xenophobic and racist rhetoric—producing responses from some readers blaming immigrants for issues in society and suggesting the deportation of millions of people. On top of it, these emails direct their frustration with immigrants to Hernández's Cuban identity.

Despite the hostility, Hernández emphasizes the importance of reporting on these stories with truth and accuracy, in this case in the context of constructing narratives of larger issues like climate change affecting immigrant communities. But most importantly of all, she encourages other journalists to continue doing meaningful work and to stay fearless and unapologetic in telling stories that highlight the diversity and challenges of American communities. In my view, that is the beauty of journalism. Journalism goes beyond a traditional definition as a process of gathering, writing, editing, and disseminating information through media, or a career for people who practice journalism. It is a value.

No media can portray itself perfectly; there are hundreds of thousands of news sources and outlets across the world, and in America, they're often grouped into one political identity, an evil superbody known as "The Media" who try everything they can to put profit above a commitment to truth and morals. Simply put, journalism is portrayed in public sentiment as consisting of white-collar workers ruled by a bureaucratic machine called "society." But isn't that too vague? How is it fair to say that one reporter or article can suddenly dictate that the whole population of reporters and media are all "fake news"? If we are looking to make our country "great again," we need to first examine what such interpretations made that reinspection of our country necessary.

Before we can flip the iceberg that is journalism, we should first break some ice. Simply put, journalism was born when the printing press was invented in Europe in the eighteenth century. The press signaled the end of the medieval conception of simultaneity—one's apprehension of a combined connectedness, fortuity, and fatality in a language of "continuity"—from rationalist secularism and marked the dawn of the age of nationalism, or in other words the birth of the imagined community of the nation facilitated by the novel and the newspaper (Anderson). These forms of capturing thoughts and scriptures provided the technical means for representing the *kind* of imagined community, that in turn is a well-enough representation of a nation.

If we take a modern example of looking at the front page of *The Washington Post*, we might find stories about the latest Supreme Court case overturned, migrant families in Texas, the latest robot in Japan, this year's Christmas-themed White House, the reigning Wimbledon champion, and Trump's latest Cabinet nominee. What makes these events seem connected? Nothing but the fact they appear in the same issue, which means that the connection between these stories is imagined. This imagined linkage is from 1) the same date and masthead appearing on the top of each page in the newspaper, and 2) they are "one-day best-sellers" in which readers know that it is in high demand and simultaneous consumption. When the newspaper reader observes exact replicas of the paper in his hands being consumed by his neighbors, shop owners, librarians, or visiting scholars, they are continually reassured that their imagined world is visibly rooted in everyday life. In other words, the mechanism that connected individuals to the world, or an imagined sense of the world, was print-capitalism. The very existence of stories to be read for societal and intellectual benefit can leave its readers vulnerable to distrust in democracy, institutions, expertise, and each other. But journalists should not take all of the blame for actions committed by their readers in response to their journalism; it is an arduous task to regain trust especially when journalism functions and responds to politics and democracy.

What is good journalism, and how can we be good readers of journalism? How are we to understand journalism as a profession, and journalism as a value? The normative answer to these questions is bound up with claims about the relationship between journalistic integrity and conduct, and a civil society capable of mass communication and hybrid forms of media literacy. In this context, the civil society can be understood as a highly-responsive, technology-savvy audience who consumes news with the same frequency and attitude as they consume online entertainment. To keep up with the comprehensive demands and speed of new technology, the

audience becomes an “expectant audience,” whose main goal for consuming news is to pass judgment on whether the news they consume is “good” or “bad. Rather, I propose that the more mindful reading of news for the expectant audience is to recognize all news stories are published for a bigger purpose of telling the narrative of complicated social disasters, which define the wider narrative of what it means to live with American political freedom.

In this paper, I argue that true objectivity in journalism is impossible, and instead, journalism should be a media read with an open mind. We can understand the point of these claims by way of accepting the historical contexts of print culture to click journalism and being better readers and writers of journalism.

The purpose of journalism is not to become the one source of information the public should rely on, but a series of sources to build one’s own opinions upon. In fact, I would like to reject the traditional standard of journalism as an always unbiased source of news. Journalism never evolved from (or should be less visible in) prioritizing public responsiveness over news-writing. The writers’ expressions of opinion in news articles are both a simultaneity and a necessity to keep readers interested. Perhaps, that is a good thing for readers—as long as the readers read journalism standing outside the frame of the author’s original intentions and use logic, and journalists “show their work” on how they arrived at a claim so readers may better understand whether to agree or not.

For journalists, we must accept that it is inevitable to be subjective in our writing, but we can still provide information that readers can use to make their own informed decisions. In this way, we can realize the good *of* journalism, rather than what journalism is good *for*.

Twenty-first-century news readers often bemoan the slippage between reporting and opinion, but this uncertainty has been in place in journalism since more than a century ago—and if true objectivity is indeed nonexistent, we must then look at how the modern consciousness in the idea of a report originated in print culture, flourishing in yellow journalism where that consciousness finds institutionalized expression, then to the allures of click journalism.

One particular moment in American journalism was the turn of the twentieth century. Print culture expanded radically from 1885 to 1910, in a period of rapid and disorienting social, political, and economic transformation. American social life became aflame with industrialization, increased immigration, the rise of the corporation and capital markets, the migration of rural workers to cities, and upended previous social rules to emphasize new values of respectability, local authority, and individual autonomy. What could the American people use to explain America to them? They turned to the burgeoning print industry. In 1870, there were about 34 newspapers per 100 households. By 1990, it rose to 94 per 100 households (Starr).

The effects brought about in part by the cheaper and better quality paper and printing processes served as dominoes in the late-nineteenth-century communication revolution. Social life became a long and sustained discussion among workers and observers of the print marketplace when

all public communication was sustained between a desire to read, gossip, and expand intellectually and geographically. Literacy rates increased, public schools and libraries multiplied, the demand for printed materials increased, and newly literate African Americans and immigrants joined the reading workforce, increasing the size of the middle class. More Americans were reading than ever before. In response, the printing industry produced newspapers, magazines, and books shaping every day's intellectual currents, political commitments, and social attitudes. Each conversation was a clear expression of the self-consciousness that we were becoming the takers of a national communication system (Forde and Foss). With people in cities more educated than before, the expanding print market led to cheaper paper and printing processes, better transportation systems, increased advertising, and everything imaginable in a communication revolution—ultimately resulting in a notion of what constituted a “desirable” account of reality within the reading public.

In 1974, James Carey wrote about recovering the “consciousness” or “interpretation of reality” embodied in the form of journalism we might characterize today as a “report,” or ultimately the truth that readers should accept on their own accord. Published in his landmark article “The Problem of Journalism History,” he encouraged journalism historians to develop a cultural history of journalism, calling for a history of the *idea* of the report rather than a history of the report. For Carey, the knowledge on how a report shapes reality was the motivation why we needed to keep a constant cultural history of journalism:

The central and as yet unwritten history of journalism is the history of the idea of a report: its emergence among a certain group of people as a desirable form of rendering reality, its changing fortunes, definitions and redefinitions over time (that is, the creation and disappearance of successive stylistic waves of reporting), and eventually, I suppose, its disappearance or radical education as an aspect of human consciousness. (Carey 90-91)

If the history of the idea of the report can tell us what we perceive as truth, then the history of the report can tell us how we perceived it. American literary theorist Kenneth Burke, best known for his arguments about rhetoric, presents a model called the pentad for analyzing written and spoken language to better understand and predict human behavior. The pentad, adds specificity to the five journalistic questions by offering insights into the following five components of a situation: “what was done (act) when or where it was done (scene), who did it (agent), how he did it (agency), and why (purpose)” (Burke XV).

Burke theorized this as a method for analyzing human actions and motivations. Because the 5 Ws of journalism and the pentad are so similar in their inquiry and analysis processes, we can reasonably conclude journalism serves the same purpose on revealing things about human motives and behaviors. Like other literary processes, journalism is a creative, imaginative, and symbolic work; those five components size up situations, names their elements, and in a way that contains an attitude toward them. As Anderson defined in *Imagined Communities*, a “nation” and its relevant terms like “nationality,” “nation-ness,” and “nationalism” are “cultural artefacts of a particular kind.” In other words, a nation is multiple realities constructed by human imagination, in which journalism fuels the construction of a nationalism “invent[ing] nations

where they do not exist.” Print capitalism had transformed the vernacular into the basis for national self-consciousness.

With each person reading the same words in a daily newspaper, face-to-face encounters are replaced with the print culture. The very notion of a national consciousness rests on the fundamentals of imagination: “Members of even the smallest nation will never know most of their fellow-members... yet in the mind of each lives the image of their community” (Anderson). Journalism brought into a lived reality an imagined consciousness—a nationalism—powerful enough to have induced millions of people to willingly die in its name.

Thus, when we study the history of journalism, we are really studying ways in which people in the past announced to the world who they were. When we look at journalism and see past the subject matter, we are left with a vital story of the growth and transformation of the human mind shaped and expressed in a form in which the mind has conceived and expressed a collective identification with a larger group since print culture took flight—the journalistic report’s role in shaping American consciousness.

Another emergence from the late-nineteenth-century communication revolution were trade publications, magazines or newspapers that provide news and information for people working in a specific industry or trade. More people wanted jobs so more writers, editors, and publishers devoted more time and ink to providing practical writing and career advice of all kinds across all genres and print industries.

All writers were understood by trade journals to write in “literary” pursuits (Forde and Foss 6). As print culture increased, the boundaries between news and fiction were fluid and permeable. Trade journals generally did not insist on a firm differentiation between whether the story was for the purpose of public communication, of advancing authorship, or what constituted journalism and imaginative literature. For example, in its third year of publication in 1886, the trade journal for journalists, *The Journalist*, identified itself as the first trade publication for “newspaper-men” and “the twin professions of literature and journalism.” These two categories were generally understood as different expressive categories, but to consider them as “twin professions” suggests that they follow socially recognized modes of cultural expression and must undergo a bureaucratized production to be published. In the same year, *The Writer*, a journal marketed to freelance writers, declared itself to be a “Monthly Magazine to Interest and Help All Literary Workers,” meaning they were really trying to help people who worked in society, the reporters, more than fiction writers and poets.

Paradoxically, these trade journals understood American print culture to be comprised of many distinct genres of public expression, modes of authorship, and forms of industrial production, but also conceptualized all of it as “literature.” But they chose to lean more heavily on the former route, replacing idealism with realism as the dominant mode of American thought and cultural expression by the 1880s and 1890s. Terms like “muckraking,” “idealism,” “naturalism,” and “romanticism” helped to categorize different writing. For the national communication system, a social preference for realism and scientific thought unsettled romantic and idealist tendencies, as Victorian notions of “truth” in the divine or horrors were displaced by, most notably, Darwin’s

theory of natural selection and Spencer's theory of human evolution and perfectibility (Shi 66-70).

It may seem like a fascination with experience and facts took hold of American society and culture, but this version of realism was more of a belief in the social importance of documenting effects, the scientific method, and the results and accomplishments of scientific discoveries. This realization marked the turn of writing styles across print culture—in news-writing and fiction-writing—as many writers, editors, and publishers recommended limiting adjectives and overly descriptive language.

One example of this urging appears in an article in the trade magazine, *The Writer*, in October 1888. In this article, writer H.L. Richards Jr. attributed this story to a duty to teach younger journalists how to work faster, “know the ropes,” and make better judgments of how to write an effective piece of news. Arguing that journalism was now a trade where most literary men have “no chance against the trained newspaper man who ‘knows the ropes,’” Richards writes,

You are told that the old order changes; that the man who succeeds now as a newspaper worker is he who has worked his way up, who “knows the ropes,” who is prompt, active, and acute in getting his facts, who can judge accurately as to the value of any piece of news, and how much of his own or any other paper will probably want to make of it, and who can write it out in a “telling,” or a “striking” or a “sensational” or an effective way... The advice of the old newspaper man to the young one, fairly epitomized, seems to be: “Learn all the ropes; get all the experience you can; acquire the art of making ‘telling’ and ‘effective’ stories, and throw overboard everything like literary style. There is no time for it; editors don’t want it, and readers don’t care for it.

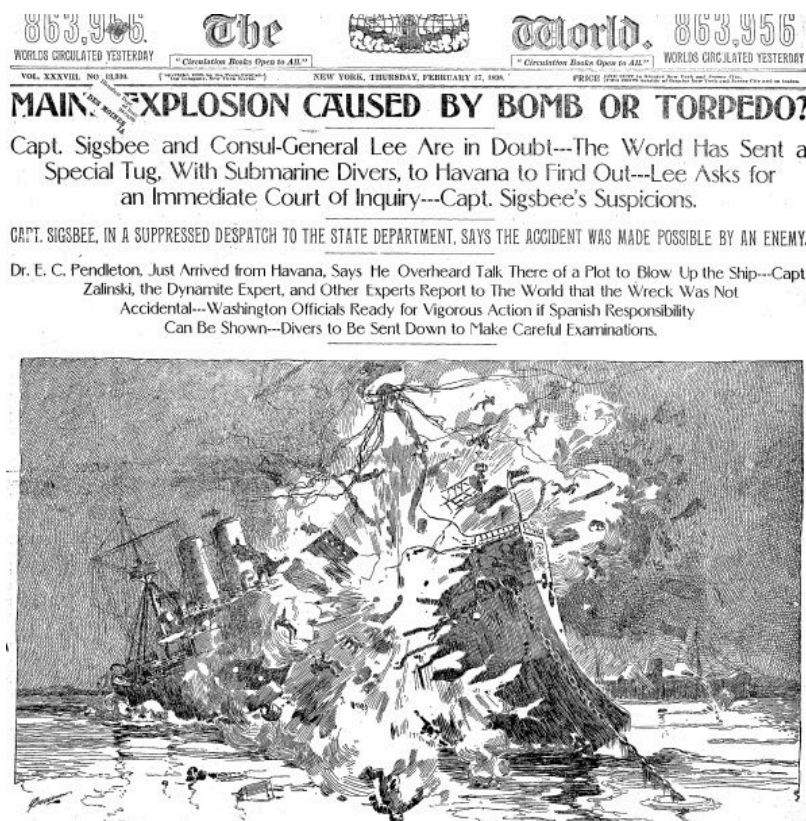
A reverence for facts and the empirical did not, however, eliminate the requisite that news must be necessary to write news. It just meant that news writing conventions now were closely aligned with the empirical spirit. In 1892, the *Journalist* noted that in the past decade, journalism had increasingly relied on presenting facts and excluding opinions. The reporter learned that “their opinions are not facts, that their opinions are not news, and they keep those opinions to themselves” (A.B.). In an 1893 book titled “The Ladder of Journalism: How to Climb It”, writer T. Campbell-Copeland insists that the essential purpose of American journalism was to report facts: “It is a common fault with young writers to be too diffuse in their reports—a circumstance to which their attention is soon called by the City Editor, for one of the first conditions of success in metropolitan journalism is the presentation to the public of the important facts and not a word more.”

Gone was the friendly, intimate, first-person narrator that characterized many forms of print expression in the previous era, and no more addressing readers as “friends” and motivations to cultivate moral and social values in the reading audience. This was “a complete elimination of the writer’s individuality,” a contributor in the *Writer* suggested. In an 1894 article titled “How to Write a Newspaper Article” in the *Journalist*, the contributor declared that “the reporter must sink his personality out of sight and merge his very identity in that of his paper. So long as he is a reporter it is an unpardonable sin for him to express his own ideas in his ‘copy.’ His business is to report facts and other people’s opinions.” News writing and gathering was becoming more like

a scientific process, scientific in nature, and scientifically secured. The narrator had become an objective, detached, removed, and impersonal voice of modern literature and journalism.

Even papers that embraced sensational journalism generally prided themselves on factual reporting, which was a common trick deployed by newspapers in the heyday of yellow journalism to push an agenda or to sell more papers. In New York, the newspaper market was especially crowded with daily newspapers (“dailies”) like the *New York Times*, *New York Evening Post*, *The World*, and the *New York Journal*, who in response to the invention of the linotype machine and the demand of interesting stories, were able to publish multiple editions every day.

In their competition to stand out among themselves, the *New York World* and the *New York Journal* enlisted the help of artists and cartoons, like the popular Yellow Kid cartoon from which the term “yellow journalism” was coined, and their headlines became bigger and more outrageous. For example, in January 1898, the U.S. battleship USS Maine was sent to Havana, Cuba, to watch over American interests during the Cuban uprising against Spain. An explosion aboard the Maine on February 15, 1898, caused it to sink in the harbor, killing 266 crew members. Although the exact cause of the accident was still unknown, within days, some newspapers were already blaming Spain, using misreported or fabricated evidence, published with large headlines and gruesome renditions.



“Maine Explosion Caused by Bomb or Torpedo?” *The World* (New York, NY), February 17, 1898.
(NewspaperARCHIVE)

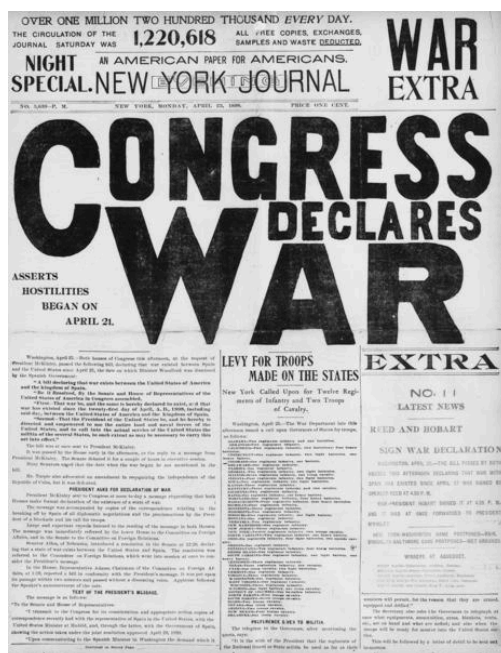


“Torpedo Hole Discovered by Government Divers in the Maine: Startling Evidence of Spanish Treachery Revealed,” New York Evening Journal (New York, NY), February 17, 1898. (New York Journal)



“Spain Guilty!” New York Evening Journal (New York, NY), March 25, 1898. (New York Evening Journal)

These headlines helped goad President William McKinley and the U.S. military to force a military response. On April 20, 1898, McKinley and Congress sent an ultimatum to Spain to withdraw from Cuba. The next day, Spain severed diplomatic ties and declared war on the U.S. Throughout this escalation of the war, the “yellowest of all these papers, the ‘Journal,’ actually printed thirty extra editions in a space of twelve or fourteen hours,” as the *Indianapolis Journal* published in an article on April 18, 1898, writing “The recipe for making a war extra is to get a line of fact or rumor and charge it with the carbonic acid gas of imagination until it fills three columns, half made up of headlines in poster type.” That is exactly what the *New York Journal* did on April 25:



“Congress Declares War,” New York Evening Journal, April 25, 1898. ([Library of Congress](https://www.loc.gov/rr/news/18980425.html))

There are three main checks to yellow journalism. Profit motive is cited as one of the drivers of the Spanish-American War, which was in part fed by accounts of yellow journals. But there was so much fakery in the news that by the early 1900s, people eventually began to mistrust what they read, leading some newspapers to differentiate themselves in the opposite direction. For example, the *New York Times* introduced its slogan “All the News That’s Fit to Print” in 1897, which it still uses in its masthead today, proving to the public the profitability of a “highly conservative paper” (Pomerantz 739). Thus, the first check was the public’s changing demands of the idea of reality (the “report”).

Specifically, the success of the *New York Times* is not due to the public demanding something better than the previous yellow journalism. The second check on yellow journalism was actually legal protection; it was because the public wanted explicit legal protection for personal privacy against unwanted private invasion, namely from the prying eyes of yellow journalists and gossip-mongers, according to an 1890 article in the *Harvard Law Review* (Warren and Brandeis). Some U.S. courts already recognized indirect legal protection for personal interests in privacy, but the publication of this landmark article incited more courts to consider more explicitly whether and how to give privacy more direct and substantial protection.

The third check was in the newspaper industry itself. In 1910, the first code of ethics for newspapers was proposed by W.E. Miller and adopted by the Kansas State Editorial Association in 1910 (Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science 289-290)¹. Similar codes were adopted across the U.S., as Eustace Cullinan described it in

¹ *Lies.—We condemn against truth:*

1955: “[i]n recent decades the press of the nation has developed a code of ethics to which it adheres within reason” (Cullinan 1063-1064).

History told by an unscrupulous press, fueled by sensation and fabrication to earn views and money, is not unfamiliar to modern readers now who deal with the fake news of today’s internet. But the rise and fall of yellow journalism offers important insights as to how fake news exists today and what the general public and its journalists can do about it. As the 1890s had the then-state-of-the-art technology of the linotype and printing press, the 21st century has the internet. Thus fake news has always been here regardless of the *technology*; in other words, the problem of fake news does not arise from technology. The Internet may have intensified and complicated fake news, but it is clear there has always been a delicate balance in journalism between public interest in factual reporting and private interests in scandalous headlines and profit.

Has more technology actually made people stupider? Currently, younger generations are struggling with their literacy skills—in 2020, Statista reported that 23% of Americans feel that they can recognize fake news, 67% believe that the spread of fake news on social media causes confusion, and 38% have shared fake news online (Statista). The Internet has not only helped spread fake news faster, but has also made it more believable and accessible. This leads to decreased media literacy and short attention spans, leading to what I call the “expectant audience”—consumers of information on the Internet and social media who take information at face value and don’t want to think critically about the media they consume.

Let’s look at a famous example about literature critics: an author writes “the curtains were blue.” The critic says, “This reflects on the generally depressed state of the protagonist.” As a reader yourself, what do you think the curtains mean? The joke goes that the author’s real intent was to simply describe the curtains as the color blue. Though there may be some truth that literary critics may go overboard and overinterpret some things, but I believe the joke misses the point for two reasons. Firstly, the author’s intent doesn’t really matter. Secondly, the question shouldn’t be about the meaning of the color of the curtains, but why a reader should know about the color in the first place. Yes, we can create a mental image of generic blue curtains in our heads from these words—and that is the power of literature to transform words into models of

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- (1) The publication of fake illustrations of men and events of news interest, however marked their similarity, without an accompanying statement that they are not real pictures of the event or person but only suggestive imitations.
 - (2) The publication of fake interview made up of the assumed views of an individual, without his consent.
 - (3) The publication of interviews in quotations unless the exact, approved language of the interviewed be used. When an interview is not an exact quotation it should be obvious in the reading that *only* the thought and impression of the interviewer is being reported.
 - (4) The issuance of fake news dispatches whether the same have for their purpose the influencing of stock quotations, elections, or the sale of securities or merchandise. Some of the greatest advertising in the world has been stolen through the news columns in the form of dispatches from unscrupulous press agents. Millions have been made on the rise and fall of stock quotations caused by newspaper lies, sent out by designing reporters.

something in another's head—but if a reader imagines that there is a link between the way the curtains are blue and everything else in the space might also be described as blue, then the link changes. The fact is, the author wants readers to know the curtains are blue, and that is inextricably tied to a larger context. The blue curtains don't mean anything by itself. But in retrospect of the details around it, then maybe there is another meaning. However, what the author actually meant doesn't matter, since nobody will ever know what the author exactly meant at the moment they wrote these descriptions.

This, too, is a power of literature and discourse—Michel Foucault in “What is an Author” posits that the the author is no longer the person who wrote the text, but a paratext that carries connotations that throw shade over the reading. Authorship and the different values and interpretations pulled from it are cultural products that vary widely through time and place. In other words, the author is essentially a projection of the manner in which we think about texts; Foucault writes that the name of the author is “unlike a proper name” in the sense that it “remains at the contours of texts—separating one from the other, defining their form, and characterizing their form of existence.” He explains that the very notion of writing makes it “subject to the test of oblivion and repression,” hence making the “death of the author” necessary whenever a reader reads a piece of text or information:

The author's name manifests the appearance of a certain discursive set and indicates the status of this discourse within a society and a culture. It has no legal status, nor is it located in the fiction of the work; rather, it is located in the break that founds a certain discursive construct and its very particular mode of being... The author function is therefore characteristic of the mode of existence, circulation, and functioning of certain discourses within a society [at the author's time]. (Foucault 5)

Applied to our age of technology in the 21st century today, we shouldn't read journalism today just to agree or disagree with the author's claim in an article. Social media should not corrupt our own thoughts, but allow us to use our critical thinking to form our own opinions. The expectant audience today consistently fails to understand media from a critical lens, leading to the miscommunication and hostility we see today, especially in the political side of social media which is more than often focused on extreme political viewpoints leading to intense polarization. In other words, writing is a performative act which only exists at the moment we read the words on the page because that is the only moment in which those words are actually given meaning—by us, who interpret them. So when we absorb information on social media, we are actually analyzing someone's reaction to their own thinking. Our critical thinking skills should be facilitated towards the influence of that thinking on ourselves, our feelings, and our behaviors, and allow ourselves to reflect, create, and react. By not practicing our critical analysis skills and seeing it as useless (“maybe the curtain is blue just because it is” rhetoric), we normalize anti-intellectualism.

To combat anti-intellectualism, we can look towards increasing media literacy in schools. Notions of media literacy have existed since the 1950s. In the United Kingdom, scholars and teachers proposed to teach students how to distinguish high culture versus popular culture through education. In the United States, the introduction of radio and television as part of

people's daily lives and education cemented the increasing impact of mass media on media literacy. Then at the beginning of the 21st century, new media technologies made traditional literacy no longer sufficient for an individual to competently survive and thrive in this Internet ecology.

In an age of click journalism and mass media, 21st-century media literacy education is not limited to just traditional writing and reading, but also diverse practices of media, global interconnectedness, and hybrid forms of communication. Many social and cultural phenomena, political shifts, historical narratives, and predictions of the future have been represented and documented in popular culture and media, which takes the forms of film, television, art, books, news, and social media. For example, in the summer of 2023, theatres internationally saw the one-time phenomenon coined "Barbenheimer."² I saw *Oppenheimer* (2023) and found it to be a critique of the U.S. military, but many others on TikTok saw it as three hours of glorifying war and propaganda. Certainly, as Barthes' theory stands, there are countless interpretations of the movie available, but personally and ethically I do not think glorifying violence should be one of them. Applying media literacy and critical thinking skills, firstly, the inclusion of something in media does not necessarily indicate the creators' support for it. Secondly, the movie has heavy implications strung throughout that signify that war is bad. Again, as Barthes describes, readers of the modern time must use their own analyzing skills to interpret the film's cultural context, emotional cues, and literary devices to at least form their own argument of the central message. Like all mediums of information, these provide perspectives and ideologies to be accepted or critiqued, and access to a range of contexts: urban or rural areas, the borderlands of multilingual communities, postindustrial or newly industrializing nation-states, traditional neighborhoods, and the virtual communities of the Internet.

How have we gotten so bad at critical thinking? I suspect it is partially due to the fact there is so *much* to process. Information is now available at our fingertips and it is impossible to have enough time to both scroll, be interested in the wide variety of that information, and maximize media consumption at the same time. This creates a tendency to "doomscroll," hours of endless scrolling where we really only have time to skim over the basic premise of a video, image, or article (more specifically, a headline) before going to the next interesting thing. Personally, I

² About *Barbie* (2023), there have been plenty of memes and shorts made on Instagram Reels, TikTok, and the like about the characters and the plot of this movie. Contrary to popular opinion, I would like to argue that the film is not entirely about female empowerment or trying to prove how women are stronger or better than men. We can call the movie an advertisement for Mattel, or as a self-aware message about capitalism or a critique of toxic patriarchy or masculinity. But ultimately, at the end of the movie, we do see the Barbies trying to make a more egalitarian society and encourage the Kens to pursue their own hopes and dreams. When Ken says 'Maybe we can even get a seat in the Supreme Court!' and President Barbie shuts them down by saying "Absolutely not, maybe a seat in the House of Representatives," it shows that there is still much work to do and Barbieland is still not quite the dream life to live, similar to how men and women in the workplace and society still have issues in the Real World. This is just my interpretation of the movie's ending, and I acknowledge that the expectant audience is able to simplify this into "Wow! Women run the world!" That reading, regardless of its generic-ness, is still a reading and it still makes certain groups of people happy. It is one thing to go with the reading that makes you most happy, but it's another to just see the pink everywhere and skim over the basic premise of the movie to arrive at that conclusion. In my view, the latter thinking process does not do the reader's right to interpretation nor the death of the Author justice.

admit that I too play the role of an expectant audience sometimes. When I fall into the doomscrolling trap, I'm forced to categorize things into binaries of what's good or bad, or if an opinion is right or wrong with no in-between. Out of the fear of misinterpretation, we tend to rely on prior knowledge to distill complex topics into simple understandings which can only be wrong, as we do not process it with an open, learning mind. There is little space for analysis or personal thought. These habits form the basis for how everyday people take in information.

So what does it mean to keep learning new things in this 21st-century information economy? Certainly, it does not mean to be stagnant and read literary texts from the past just to master the content or the traditional texts students used in past classrooms: standardized textbooks, mass-produced student workbooks, teachers' manuals, standardized reading tests, etc.—the assumption that those methods are how people naturally acquire and use literacy best is itself a product of the early 20th century. Rather than a complete replacement of the “old media education,” however, I actually see these new technologies (social media, online media consumption) as transforming or forming into a hybrid with the older systems of communication (TV, cinema, textbooks). After all, the existence of a paper like this already proves it is quite necessary to investigate new and old media.

Instead of banning TikTok as bill S.1143 and H.R.231 condemn, it's the source of information that matters, not the social media platform. TikTok, although accessible to a large number of creators in the world, is a platform for opinions and interpretations of facts. Anybody can say something on the app, but can anybody say something accurate? The U.S. government believes that the Chinese Communist Party can easily manipulate content on the app. But the problem is really that Americans think it is okay to replace news outlets with social media influencers. Just as people complain that the superbody known as “The Media” is too focused on turning journalism into profit, to be a social media influencer also means to do social media for the sake of making a profit out of consumer attention. Controversial or strange posts that generate strong feelings capture users' notice, hold their attention for longer, and provide advertisers with more opportunities to monetize engagement. Plus, if TikTok is banned, many of its users are likely to migrate to Instagram and YouTube for information, exposing people to the same attention-grabbing content as before.

Thus, we can argue that the media is not merely shaping our culture; it *is* our culture. Just as artificial intelligence today causes collective anxiety but also immense excitement in society, new technology is equipping individuals with the desire to obtain new literacies to fully engage in that ecology.

So, how *can* we be good readers of journalism? Good readers are mindful of the frame they read journalism from, meaning they have to switch gears from ones who read conclusions to those who read the evidence and comprehend the reasoning. Most importantly, above being a reader, they are also citizens as part of an American democracy. Charles Taylor, in his essay titled “Liberal Politics and the Public Sphere,” claims that public opinions can only be developed in an environment where public conversation on public matters is possible. He says that instead of mankind's opinions being seen as “(1) unreflected, (2) unmediated by discussion and critique, and (3) passively inculcated in each successive generation.” Public opinion, conversely, should

be “(1)... the product of reflection, (2) to emerge from discussion, and (3) to reflect an actively produced consensus” (Taylor 261).

An environment that nurtures public conversation makes possible the autonomous participation of citizens—a defining element of a flourishing civil society. As Christopher Tollefsen puts it, “Call this aspect of a successful community ‘self-rule’... First, there can be no genuine self-rule if there is no common deliberation... Common deliberation is necessary both to determine who will bear the necessary authority in final determination [of the central message of an article], and to provide guidance for that final determination” (Tollefsen 296-297). It is the special feature of journalism both as a practice and as a profession that bestows readers an incredible power to discuss the content but also to give a second meaning to that content by its interpretation.

The profession of journalism should be understood by readers as the internal good of the practices that compose it and the institutional context from which its conduct and ethics are derived. Understanding that the obligation to follow these rules makes journalists an obligatory but reluctant “steward” of democracy. Regardless of whether they are professional journalists or amateur journalists, they have a craft knowledge of deciding what to write (thus defining “news”) based on public significance, popular interest, and immediate values. Good writers are those who write normative claims to uphold democracy, like “stewards of democracy,” and who “show their work,” not those who write for profit or power—separating journalistic practice from the practice of journalism seen in the corporate workplace.

As I described in previous sections, it is impossible to have complete objectivity in journalism. There is a long list of exceptions to “just the facts” journalism, not only under the guise of click and sensational journalism but also highly respected ones too, in news stories and even scientific papers. Just as narration and directed storytelling exist in all writing, there are also many expectations of journalists and newsrooms to be more diverse and represent minority populations. For example, in its beginnings in 1926, the British Broadcasting Company (BBC) was given the mission to promote a sense of “Britishness” that included celebrating a distinctively British heritage. To highlight the intensity of their commitment, the company was even sworn allegiance to the practices of the Church of England (Seaton). Of course, America is religiously tolerant and it would turn the stomachs of many American journalists to commit to that intensity.

Still, American journalists also act in ways that show their obligation and affiliation to the United States. When there is a story they think may impact national security, they may customarily notify the government and negotiate the content of the story with relevant agencies, like when *The New York Times* notified the White House on the Bay of Pigs invasion in 1961 and when *The Washington Post* alerted the National Security Agency in 1986 of a secret communications operation called “Ivy Bells” (Schudson 160). While in both circumstances, the journalists did have the upper hand in deciding how and when to spin the tale, they still negotiated with the government officials in a balance of maintaining national security and being the first to cover these exclusive headlines.

Many of my journalism mentors have repeated to me that connections are the number one key to moving up the social ladder in the journalism industry. Likewise, that means the power that

people you may never have met before—sources, mentors, and audiences—exercise over news makes representing democracy's best interests difficult precisely because journalists do not control their vocational agenda. On top of that, journalists often enter the industry with a high moral purpose and a love of writing, photography, traveling, or digital expression without much of a sense as to which beat they'll eventually settle on covering. So realistically, many reporters follow the rule of journalism where they leave codes, doctrines, and textbooks behind and be led by reality itself. To move up in the journalism rankings, this usually means placing a high value on reporting rather than opining.

But is reporting truly more grounded-to-earth than opining? Many journalists value writing about just facts; *New York Times* reporter Harrison Salisbury, with nearly 50 years of journalism experience, wrote in his memoir that he took on journalism with a "fierce antagonism to idealogues" and preferred to see himself as "a hard-hitting, two-fisted, call-them-as-they-come reporter." On the other hand, Political commentator Andrew Sullivan said in a 2011 lecture at Harvard University, "[M]aybe it's because I am British, [but] I think our job is to say things that no one else will say and to find out things that make people very uncomfortable, the powerful and the powerless. I think our job is not to worry about the impact of what we find out and say but to say what we think and to report what we see." Sullivan has a Harvard Ph.D. and has been a successful blogger since 2000. Does that make Sullivan's position less responsible than Salisbury's? Salisbury's take on journalism's responsibility is reminiscent of the "old newspaper man", while Sullivan's takes on the form of a rebellious, truth-seeking missile. Just as Barthes says there are countless interpretations of media, if readers read these types of stories from the perspective of someone outside the frames of subjectivity, readers will be better equipped to make their own informed decisions on the narratives told by these stories.

The definition of a good journalist does not rest on whether they represent a democracy well or not, but on what sort of stewardship and language best serves a democratic society. Ultimately, the point of journalism is to teach others how to be their own journalists as they inform themselves on what is true and false, or what they should believe in versus what they should take with a grain of salt. The purpose of journalism is to equip individuals with facts and reasoning to create their own opinions on complicated historical and current issues.

One beauty of journalism is that anybody can write. Journalism is a field that dances on a knife edge between accepted professionalism and pure amateurism. They're not doctors or engineers who are respected for their mastery of the body or bridges and canals—regardless of whether they majored in journalism or picked it up as a "citizen journalist," each journalist earns respect from their writing and conduct. Schudson asks these deep questions:

In practice, journalists frequently go beyond this craft knowledge to feel obligations to some ideal or authority higher than outdoing a rival, winning a more desirable audience, or pleasing their journalistic peers. But just what is that elusive higher authority? An allegiance to the public good? What do journalists know of that? That is, on what

grounds do they presume to know more than others do? Or is the higher authority democracy? But what do journalists know of democracy that is unknown to ordinary mortals? Or is truth their ultimate objective? What do they know of truth that the rest of us do not? (Schudson 166)

There is no Supreme Court of journalism, so there is no definitive statement that can answer these questions. We have yet to scrutinize if journalism has developed a widespread code of conduct as to what its plan and purpose in democracy is, and if that plan is ethical to expect of all journalists in the first place. But, as a journalist myself, I *can* say that journalism has the ability to tell stories out of seemingly nothing. Journalism has never been single-mindedly devoted to its watchdog role, and has continuously proven itself to serve democracy in a variety of ways throughout American history: providing citizens with information-centered political news, offering political analyses, undertaking investigative reporting, presenting emotional and social stories, informing citizens about things previously unknown or confused about, attending to democratic processes, mobilizing citizens for politics, and many, many more. The industry still has room for improvement in better serving democratic ends, but we are already on the path to good journalism if there is a variety of news genres and balances of public and private interests.

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